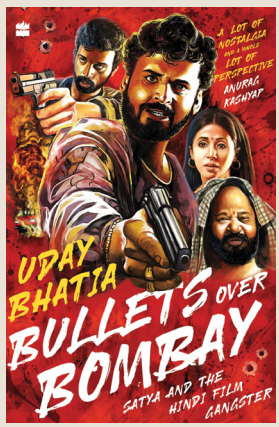
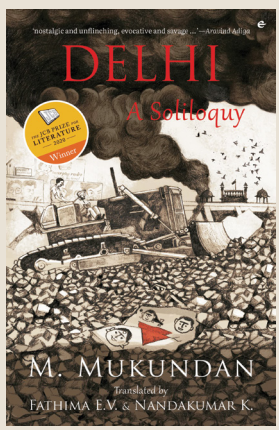
BOOKMARKING 2021







From the return of big names to Covid becoming a literary protagonist, 2021 had something for us all

Last year's most anticipated publishing event was perhaps the unveiling of Sally Rooney's latest novel. *Beautiful World, Where Are You* joined a roster of old heavyweights returning with new work: Maggie Nelson, Colm Tóibín, Jhumpa Lahiri and Salman Rushdie. South Africa's Damon Galgut picked up the Booker, fiction's top honour, for *The Promise*, his decades-long multi-generational story of a white family during and after apartheid.

The Baillie Gifford, non-fiction's big prize went to *Empire of Pain* on the Sackler dynasty and the American opioid crisis by the *New Yorker's* Patrick Radden Keefe. The Women's Prize for Fiction found itself in a spot of bother when some women condemned the longlisting of a transwoman (Torey Peters). Her excellent debut novel, *Detransition, Baby*, eventually lost to Susanna Clark's *Piranesi*. In South Asia, the Rs 25 lakh JCB Prize went to M. Mukundan's Malayalam novel *Delhi: A Soliloquy*.

Indian non-fiction showed its bench strength across formats. Examinations of pop culture and sociological phenomena flourished by way of *Bullets over Bombay* (Uday Bhatia) and *Desperately Seeking Shah Rukh* (Shrayana Bhattacharya). Sonia Faleiro's *Good Girls* was a masterful work of journalism, unpacking a hanging in Uttar Pradesh, while other accomplished women journalists with books out in 2021 included Rukmini S.'s deep data dive (*Whole Numbers and Half Truths*) and Kavitha Iyer's dogged reporting on the agrarian crisis (*Landscapes of Loss*).

As the virus mutated, it became a bona fide literary trope, giving us the beginnings of a recognisable subgenre—pandemic fiction. Sarah Hall's *Burntcoat* explored lovers caught in lockdown, Gary Shteyngart's *Our Country Friends* brought us pals riding out the pandemic in a rural retreat. Jodi Picoult, in *Wish You Were Here*, crafted a thriller around the Covid-induced claustrophobia. In India, Puja Changoiwala's *Homebound* plunged into the migrant exodus through the voice of a teenager and Namita Gokhale acknowledged the pandemic in her family saga, *Blind Matriarch*.

Doom and gloom generally mean a murder mystery boom. Big names returned with mysteries of the cosy, English (Anthony Horowitz) and twisty, thrilling (Paula Hawkins) varieties. Rijula Das won a Tata Book Award with *A Death in Shonagachhi* and *Murder at the Mushaira* by Raza Mir brought us a mysterious death against the backdrop of the 1857 rebellion. Senior crime journalists inserted authenticity into their maiden novelistic attempts, including Mohamed Thaver with *In Plain Sight*, a gripping police procedural, and Abhishek Sharan, who co-authored a counter-terror thriller, *Operation Trojan Horse*. ■

–Bhavya Dore



INCISIVE WRITING
(clockwise from left) Damon Galgut, Sonia Faleiro and Jhumpa Lahiri

Indian writers showed their strength in various genres and the world saw the emergence of a new one—**PANDEMIC FICTION**